Among the communities most affected were the Nadars, Thiyyas and Ezhavas, many of whom plied the same trade: tending and tapping the sap of the palmyra palm to produce an unrefined sugar called jaggery and liquor in the form of toddy and arrack, hence their nicknames of ‘toddy-tappers’ or ‘climbers’. The Nadars regarded themselves as a warrior people originating from Tamil Nadu, whereas the Thiyyas and Ezhavas both claimed that their ancestors had been brought from Ceylon at the request of a Chera king to establish coconut farming in Kerala. These claims support the theory that their forebears were Buddhists whose refusal to abandon their religion had led to their being declared outcaste.